Doctrinal.

"If any man will do His will he shall know of the doctrine whether it be of God."—*John 7:17.*

LOVE.

BY C. ASA.

TRUE love, a spirit of heavenly birth,
A being not born of the groveling earth;
Sweet hope she brings down to the heart of the pure;
Her promise is lasting, and ever is sure
As the throne of Jehovah himself.

Where'er among brethren this spirit may be,
They all dwell together in sweet unity;
Their trials are one, for love is their song,
And this is the power that bears them along
To the throne of Jehovah himself.

THE THREE MESSAGES OF REV. 14:6–12.

BY ELDER E. W. WHITNEY.

No. 1. Nature, and How Understood.

"And I saw another angel fly in the midst of heaven, having the everlasting gospel to preach unto them that dwell on the earth, and to every nation, and kindred, and tongue, and people, saying with a loud voice, Fear God, and give glory to him; for the hour of his judgment is come; and worship him that made heaven, and earth, and the sea, and the fountains of waters. And there followed another angel, saying, Babylon is fallen, is fallen, that great city, because she made all nations drink of the wine of the wrath of her fornication. And the third angel followed them, saying with a loud voice, If any man worship the beast and his image, and receive his mark in his forehead, or in his hand, the same shall drink of the wine of the wrath of God, which is poured out without mixture into the cup of his indignation; and he shall be tormented with fire and brimstone in the presence of the holy angels, and in the presence of the Lamb; and the smoke of their torment ascendeth up forever and ever; and they have no rest day nor night, who worship the beast and his image, and whosoever receiveth the mark of his name. Here is the patience of the saints; here are they that keep the commandments of God, and the faith of Jesus." Rev. 14:6–12.

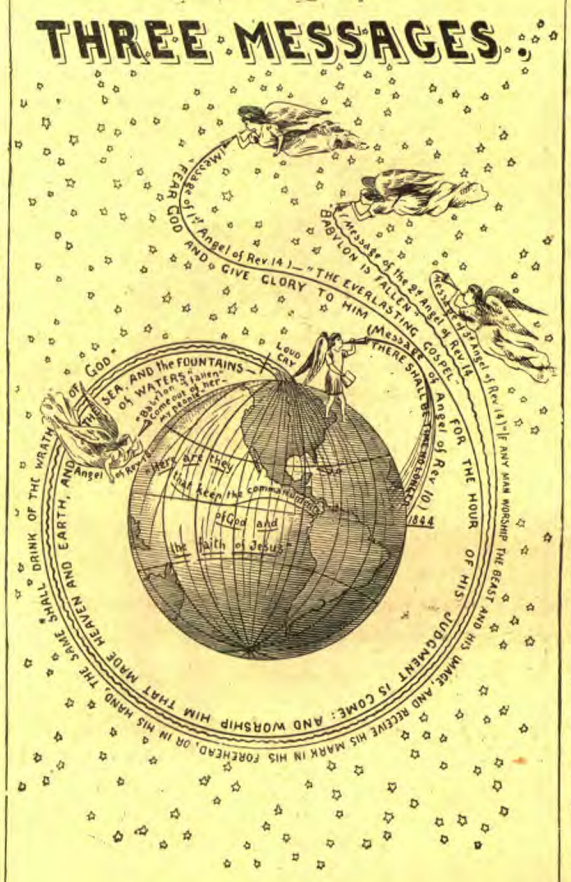
NONE who love the word of God, and desire to understand it, can read thoughtfully this scripture without becoming interested to know its meaning and application. Were the book in which it is found, as is so often inconsistently affirmed, "a sealed book," the case would be different. But when the angel who presents these things to John, says at the beginning, "Blessed is he that readeth, and they that hear the words of this prophecy, and keep those things which are written therein; for the time is at hand" (chapter 1:3), and when he says again at the close, speaking as the representative of Christ, whose angel he was (see chapter 1, verse 1), "Behold, I come quickly; blessed is he that keepeth the sayings of the prophecy of this book," repeating, "for the time is at hand" (chapter 22:7, 10), the searcher for light has the fullest warrant for studying, and the blessed assurance that he may understand and obey.

The portion under consideration in these articles embraces what is frequently called "The Three Angels' Messages," from the fact that, as John saw three angels flying "in the midst of heaven," of the last one he says, "And the *third* angel followed them," which implies that only two others preceded this one connected with this series, or with his then present vision.

The first is represented as preaching the gospel to dwellers upon the earth; but we know that the preaching of the gospel "to every creature" "in all the world" was committed by Christ himself to men. Mark 16:15. Angels, it is true, as direct messengers from God (Heb. 1:14), assist men, and by their influence over those who desire and yield to it, may be said to direct in the work; yet they operate through human agents in accomplishing it. So while actual angels may have charge of the work symbolized by these messages, yet the work itself must be one in which men are the active agents. The importance of the work is, however, more strikingly presented by the selection of angels as bearers of the message.

Three angels appear; each proclaims a distinct message; yet, carefully studied, these messages are found to be really but one, rather, a leading, principal message, followed or joined by two others contingent upon, and made necessary by, the rejection of the first.

This principal message is comprehensive



NOTES UPON THE ILLUSTRATION.

1. THE first message begins previous to 1844, announcing the hour of judgment, but continues to the coming of Christ, proclaiming the gospel and the worship of the true God (the commandments) as the basis of the following messages. 2. Simultaneously with the opening of the first message, and as a special feature of its introduction, it is joined by the message of the angel of chapter 10, which continues to 1844 and ceases. 3. Subsequent to 1844 the truths of the first message became more fully understood and preached, though generally rejected, and as a consequence it is joined by the second message, proclaiming the fall of Babylon, which also continues to the end. 4. Later the two are joined by the third, warning against the worship of "the beast" and his image and the reception of his mark, and also continues to the end. 5. Just before the end of gospel work the three are joined by the message of chapter 18, announcing the complete fall of Babylon, and calling upon God's people to come out of her because of her sins. c This in effect produces a loud, earnest, and extended giving of all three messages combined, resulting in the lighting of the earth with all truth, and the development of a company keeping all the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus, and fully prepared to meet Christ when he appears in the clouds of heaven.

in its nature, embracing as it does, considering the terms employed, a complete system of truth, and a perfect worship, added to which, as an incentive to heed the message, the announcement that the "hour of God's judgment is come." The acceptance of the "everlasting gospel," and the true worship of "him that made heaven and earth, and the sea, and the fountains of waters," must embrace every moral and Christian duty, and secure every Christian privilege and blessing; in short, must fit the recipient perfectly for the judgment.

The second message is a statement of a single fact, with the reason for it: "Babylon is fallen, is fallen, that great city, because she made all nations drink of the wine of the wrath of her fornication." All that need be said in this connection concerning it is that the term "Babylon," used here symbolically, is the same as that found in chapter 18, from which it is evident that whatever it symbolizes, it is that in which at the time of its fall God's people are found; and further, that the fall is a moral one through sin, for "Babylon the great is fallen, is fallen, and is become the habitation of devils, and the hold of every foul spirit, and a cage of every unclean and hateful bird," therefore, "come out of her, my people, that ye be not partakers of her sins, and that ye receive not of her plagues. For her sins have reached unto heaven, and God hath remembered her iniquities." Rev. 18:2, 4, 5. It is because of her sins that God calls his people out of her, in order that they receive not of her plagues.

The third message is remarkable. It is spoken with a loud voice, as is the first. The first calls upon all to worship the Creator—the true God. This warns *every man*, in most striking language, against the worship of powers evidently opposed to God, but which demand worship due alone to him. This warning is emphasized by the most fearful threatening of punishment upon those who do not heed it, to be found in all the Bible, the "*wrath of God*" "*without mixture.*" The only modifying element ever mixed with wrath is mercy. This, then, will be wrath without any mercy. In chapter 15, verse 7, we read of seven angels, having "seven golden vials full of the wrath of God." With the commonly accepted idea that, in Scripture, the number seven denotes completeness, we have in this an expression of God's unmixed wrath—evidently God's wrath after the period of mercy is forever past. From chapter 16, verse 19, we learn that this wrath comes upon Babylon, for "great Babylon came in remembrance before God, to give unto her the cup of the wine of the fierceness of his wrath." It comes upon Babylon after God's people have left her; for the announcement is first made, "Babylon is fallen, is fallen" (chapter 14:8 and 18:2); and then the call is given, "Come out of her, my people," and lastly the statement and command concerning her: "God hath remembered her iniquities. Reward her even as she rewarded you, and double unto her double according to her works." By this it is seen that the punishment threatened in the third message comes upon Babylon, whose fall is announced by the second angel, thus connecting these two messages directly.

The result of the third message is to develop a people of whom it is said, "Here is the patience of the saints, here are they that keep the commandments of God, and the faith of Jesus." Rev. 14:12. These were once in Babylon, but accepted the call to come out, and rejected the false worship of which the message warns. The fall of Babylon is not announced until after the proclamation of the world-wide gospel message of the first angel, from which it may be reasonably concluded that her fall, being a spiritual one, is consequent, in a measure, at least, upon the rejection of light and truth which that message brought to her. Had that light been received as it might have been, the two succeeding messages would not have been necessary. This will more fully appear from further presentation of the subject in future articles.

One more consideration may be noticed,